

favourite among travellers and rail enthusiasts. Its beginnings can be attributed to the vision of Franklin Prestage, an Eastern Bengal Railway agent, who first proposed the idea of a train connecting Darjeeling with the plains in 1878.



Darjeeling railway station signboard

Beginnings

Prestage believed that building the line was a good way of reducing costs for bullock cart transport for freight, such as rice, which cost “Rs 238 a ton in Darjeeling” compared to “Rs 98 in Siliguri”. The scheme was approved in April 1879 and construction began at the end of that year. Built to closely follow Hill Cart Road that connected Darjeeling to Siliguri, the DHR was constructed in three phases and opened in 1881. Initially privately held, the Indian Government bought DHR in October 1948, one year after Independence, to assist with building a line to [Assam](#).